Do Religious Leaders Matter?

An Empirical Study on Transitions and Votings in Russia

Abstract

This paper investigates whether natural leadership transitions in the Russian Orthodox Church influence regional vote shares for Vladimir Putin. Using a manually collected dataset on bishop deaths and retirements between 2000 and 2025, I employ a staggered difference-in-differences regression design. I find no significant evidence that bishop transitions affect electoral outcomes, a result that holds across multiple robustness checks. While the creation of new dioceses is correlated with higher vote shares, this relationship is likely endogenous. The findings suggest that the political influence of religious leaders in modern Russia may be quite limited. However, the zero results might also be caused by noisy data or heterogeneous effects.

1 Introduction

Historically, religious figures have been important players in the political realm. In recent times, however, their power appears to have declined, and for most Christian churches, it is now limited to moral questions regarding fertility or minority rights. At the same time, nowadays, most part of the Churches' funding comes from governments, and there might be some conflict of interests leading religious leaders to overly support the parties in power. The Russian setting might tend to pave the way for similar phenomena, as there has been one ruling party for a longer period of time, so there might be an entrenched relationship between the Orthodox Church and the Political Power.

Despite a rich for exogenous variation institutional setup, religion in Russia, as well as its relation to political aspects, appears to be understudied. My project is set to introduce research within the field in order to potentially later fill this gap. The main question of the study is whether natural transitions of religious leaders of the Orthodox Church affect political outcomes of long-living incumbent parties in Russia, measured as the share of votes cast in favor of Vladimir Putin.

As a large multinational country, Russia is divided into administrative regions not only in political terms, but also in terms of church administration – into mitropolia and dioceses. Each diocese has a spiritual leader, namely, a bishop appointed almost for a lifetime by the Church's Council. Following Jones and Olken (2005), I exploit the natural source of variation in the timing of death or the reaching of the retirement age to study whether newly appointed bishops matter in terms of political outcomes. I suspect a mechanism where an entrenched incumbent-supporting council appoints new bishops that are more politically engaged or even affiliated with the ruling party.

I manually collect data on leader transitions within the Russian Orthodox Church between 2000 and 2025. I split that data into four according election terms and aggregate it at the regional level. I then match the transitions with voting data collected from

the Central Election Commission of the Russian Federation (2024) and run a staggered difference-in-differences regression in order to identify any effects.

I do not find any significant results supporting my proposed mechanism. Natural transitions appear not to affect voting behavior at the regional level. The absence of the effect remains when I restrict the sample to transitions within the main archi-diocese (the mitropoly), to transitions happening after 2009 (when Patriarch Kirill came to power), or to transitions that replace a bishop assigned prior to the year 2000 (Putin's first term). I do find a positive correlation between vote shares and the creation of new dioceses; however, as opposed to regular transitions, these cannot be interpreted causally, with decisions to create new dioceses being rather endogenous.

There are three potential causes for my lack of findings. First, there could indeed not be any effects, meaning that religious leaders actually only care about spiritual aspects and either do not try to or do not succeed in affecting political outcomes. Second, regional-level data might simply be too noisy for identification. Notably, elections in the Russian Federation are subject to serious allegations regarding falsification and vote-buying which might indeed add unnecessary variance to my measure of the outcome variable. Finally, the finding of zero effects might represent erroneous averaging of heterogeneous non-zero effects. Notably, in the original work of Jones and Olken (2005) the authors examine changes in the *variance* of outcomes as opposed to changes in the outcomes by themselves. It might indeed be the case that religious leaders do indeed matter but are in fact not appointed strategically by the Church Council, so that a transition from an apolitical to a political bishop is as likely as the reverse.

My project is at too early a stage to be able to make any claims regarding policy implications. Technically, if I were to find positive effects of religion on voting in a future study, this would call for caution in terms of filtering the information people receive at preaches in churches. If I were to confirm the zero results, it would suggest that the Orthodox Church is either 'clean' of political accusations, or simply does not succeed in this sphere.

My project relates to the literature on leaders and leader transitions. The most important reference here is Jones and Olken (2005) who show that GDP growth rates as well as different policy outcomes are affected by leadership transitions coming from deaths in office. They also argue that the effects are largest in autocratic countries. Besley et al. (2011) extend this study to show that the education of incoming leaders is important for predicting the direction of change in growth. In a study more related to religion and political power, Meyersson (2014) points out that Islamic rule (of parties) in Turkey has increased secular female education as well as reduced the amount of adolescent marriages. My project combines the two ideas of political transitions and religious power in order to examine leaders in Russia.

My work also relates to the study of religion, a relatively new field in economics. Here,

most studies focus on historical settings, as, for instance, Becker and Woessmann (2009) provide evidence that Protestantism increased literacy rates in Europe, thereby affecting economic growth, while Basten and Betz (2013) fail to find a robust effect of beliefs on work ethics. Most studies of contemporaneous religion focus on Muslims, as, for example, Campante and Yanagizawa-Drott (2015) show that participation in the Ramadan reduces productivity. Most studies of contemporaneous Christianity restrict themselves to effects on fertility (Sander, 1992; Berman et al., 2018). Iyer (2016) is a good reference for a more detailed description of the field. My study might be the first to examine political effects of religion in modern Russia.

The remainder of the project is structured as follows: Section 2 describes the general setting of the Russian Orthodox Church and bishop transitions therein. It also describes the proposed potential mechanisms of effects. Section 3 describes the data collection process and gives some general idea of regional statistics. Section 4 describes the empirical strategy and shows the results of the approach. Finally, Section 5 concludes.

2 Background, Setting, and Potential Mechanisms

In this Section I describe the institutional background of my study. First, in Subsection 2.1, I describe the Russian Orthodox Church and its subdivisions in general. Second, in Subsection 2.2 I describe how and when bishop transitions happen in dioceses. Finally, in Subsection 2.1, I suggest some potential mechanisms of why political transitions might, in fact, have an effect on political outcomes and provide some anecdotal evidence.

2.1 Federal Division of the Russian Orthodox Church

The Russian Orthodox Church comprises several exarchates, mitropolia, and dioceses. An exarchate is a subdivision of the Church that administers a separate country, as, for example, the Orthodox Church of Moldova or the Mitropolitan Region of Astana-Kazakhstan. Mitropolia, or archi-dioceses, cover entire regions and coincide with them in terms of administrative borders. One exception is the Saint-Petersburg mitropoly that covers both the Federal City, as well as the surrounding Leningrad Oblast. Notably, not all regions are covered by a mitropoly.

Each mitropoly is divided into several dioceses, with the maximum division being a split into five. A diocese is always a larger division than a municipality, with the average diocese covering about seven to ten rayons. However, usually, the borders still coincide with the borders of the included municipalities. All regions that are not covered by a mitropoly are completely covered by a single diocese of direct subordination. The only exceptions are the Republics of Chechnia and Ingushetia that are combined into one diocese. Notably, there are also dioceses of direct subordination covering foreign countries, as, for instance, the Berlin-German Diocese or the Argentinian-and-South-American diocese.

Figure A1 in the Appendix shows a graphical representation of a typical mitropoly. The Vologdan region is divided into three dioceses. Notably, there is one main archi-diocese and two regular dioceses. Each of them comprises about seven municipalities. Technically, the regular dioceses are subordinate to the main one, but there is some significant amount of freedom.

For my analysis I will only use the dioceses that are located on the territory of the Russian Federation within the borders from 2014. As of October 2025, there is a total number of 61 mitropolia. That means the 19 remaining regions are covered directly by dioceses. Notably, the Autonomous Regions of Khanty-Mansiysk and Yamalo-Nenetsk are considered separate dioceses of direct subordination, while the Nenetsk Autonomous Region is covered by the diocese of Mezen-and-Naryan-Mar that is subordinated to the Arkhangelsk Mitropoly.

There is a total of 202 dioceses, including the 61 archi-dioceses of each mitropoly. In some regressions, I exclude regions where Christianity is not the main religion. Namely, I exclude dioceses from the Republics of Bashkortostan, Chechnia, Dagestan, Ingushetia, Kabardino-Balkaria, Karachaevo-Cherkessia, and Tatarstan. In these specifications, there is a total of 193 dioceses to consider.

2.2 Leader Transition in Dioceses and Mitropolia

Each diocese has a bishop assigned to it – a leader, whose tasks usually also include both spiritual and administrative work. The bishop is appointed by the Church Council and approved by the Patriarch himself. In dioceses subordinate to mitropolia, the archi-bishop usually has the right to suggest but not independently appoint a bishop by himself.

A bishop can be replaced in three cases. First, very simply, if he dies. Second, there is a rule that gives the Church Council the *right* to retire a bishop when he reaches the age of 75 years. Notably, this right is not always exercised, and some bishops are left in duty. Additionally, if it is decided to leave a bishop in duty, his right to remain in position cannot be revoked. Finally, a bishop can be dishonorably discharged of his duties if he commits some serious violations. For dioceses located in Russia, there are only three such cases. One such case happened in 2002, when a bishop had a car accident resulting in the death of a person. The two other cases occurred in 2020 and were related to alcohol abuse and apparently sexual misconduct.

Notably, bishops can rarely also be moved between dioceses. In most cases, this happens when a position opens at a larger or more important diocese, so some experienced bishop is moved to that place, while his position is given to a new inexperienced person. Additionally, in rare cases of subordinate dioceses, a position can remain vacant for a longer period of time. In these cases, the temporary administration of the diocese falls into the hands of the archi-bishop of the according mitropoly. Usually, such vacancies are filled within the following months, but there is one exception of the Volgodon-Salsk

diocese, that remained vacant for over two years.

Finally, a very important feature of the Russian Orthodox Church is that it is very young in the form it is administered currently, so that it is growing and changing rapidly. More specifically, every year there are multiple administrative splits, where either one region-specific diocese is split into two thereby becoming a mitropoly, or within a mitropoly there is a new diocese created with subordinate territories usually coming from several previously existing dioceses.

For the remainder of the study, it is important to not confuse relocations and splits with natural transitions. While it might be possible to argue in favor of exogenous relocations, with alternative positions opening randomly, the split and creation of a new diocese will definitely never be exogenous, as it would most likely be occasioned by a preceding increase in the number of Orthodox Christians.

2.3 Suggested Potential Mechanisms

The Church in Russia is mostly supported by tax money and only partially by direct donations from sponsors. Technically, the government could cut or reduce funding for the Church, which leaves room for political pressure from the government towards religious leaders. Moreover, the Church might be subject to social pressure, adding concerns for bishops and the patriarch regarding whether they would want to befriend a ruling party.

I suspect that this potential for political pressure might create room for a conflict of interests for religious leaders, leading them to be overly political and even appeal to support the ruling party. Technically, in some questions where political factors conflict with spiritual ones, a bishop might be pressured into taking the side of the ruling party even if it somewhat contradicts the spiritual mandate of the Christian church. For instance, in the case of the Russian-Ukrainian conflict, the Bible might tell us to love our enemies and to approach peaceful solutions, while the social norms of the country might suggest supporting and even enrolling for the army in order to defend the homeland.

In Russia, a main ruling party has been present for a longer period of time. With the beginning of the 21st century, United Russia and Vladimir Putin in particular gained serious power. Economic and political literature tells us that long-lasting rules tend to create nepotistic networks and entrenched corrupt relationships at the personal level (Bazzi et al., 2024). In 2009, Patriarch Kirill came to power, who is rumored (but not proven) to have quite friendly personal relationships with Vladimir Putin himself.

It might be reasonable to suggest that bishops would start implementing some political appeals into their preaching in order to gain support from the local or federal government. Moreover, it might be reasonable to assume that the selection of appointed bishops might change, with the political potential of a candidate starting to overshadow the spiritual potential. Finally, the *mandate* of newly appointed bishops might differ from the mandate of old bishops appointed to duty prior to the empowerment of United Russia.

Importantly, it might not be the preaching of the bishop by himself that might affect voter behavior. More likely, a newly appointed bishop with a new mandate of supporting the government would most probably affect and discipline his clerical subordinates so that they would also start including political appeals into their job. This, in turn, might be what would affect voters and voting behavior.

In order to show some suggestive anecdotal evidence for the mechanism described above, I consider some recent transitions in more detail. Figure A2 shows the inauguration speech of Patriarch Kirill for the most recent appointment of the bishop of the Kasimov-and-Sasov diocese (Ryazan Region) that took place on September 1st, 2025. The inauguration speech literally mandates the new bishop to 'build up good and constructive relationships with local government authorities'. Moreover, it calls upon for work in the spheres of 'spiritual and moral education of the younger generation' as well as 'feeding of military personnel'. These tasks are even named to be of similar value to the spiritual labor of the construction of Orthodox churches. Notably, this is the transition that occurred most recently, which means that I did not even have to search for similar mandates stated explicitly during the inauguration of a local leader.

It is important to note that I assume older leaders to be less biased towards politics. This might be reasonable as some leaders were appointed when United Russia was not that powerful, and some bishops were even appointed a long time before Putin's rule. Hence, such bishops would be unlikely to have such an explicit mandate as the one I discuss above. At the same time, it might also happen that older leaders still receive the same amount of social pressure as well as some pressure through the funding channel, resulting in a similar amount of effort devoted to political questions.

3 Data

In this Section, I describe the data collection process and show some descriptive statistics. Subsection 3.1 describes bishop transitions, while subsection 3.2 shows voting outcomes.

3.1 Bishop Transitions

I manually collect data on bishop transitions. I take the data from an open encyclopedia (Drevo, 2025) that collects information relevant to the Russian Orthodox Church. Importantly, this website is not an official source, so, where it is possible, I verify the information on the direct websites of the dioceses. Unfortunately, not all dioceses provide historical information on their websites, so it is not possible to do the verification completely. However, for those dioceses that I check, I do not find any discrepancies, suggesting that the website is quite accurate.

Drevo (2025) has an individual page for each diocese that usually includes various information on the history, such as the date of creation or information about predecessors in the times of the Russian Empire. It also might include some random statistics, such

as the number of churches or the number of clerus workers calculated in a very specific year. Additionally, there is usually a list of municipalities or cities falling under the administration of the diocese, as well as a map showing the diocese relative to the territory of the Russian Federation.

Most importantly, each page of a diocese contains information about all the ruling bishops throughout history. These include the clerical name of the bishop (which usually differs from the secular name), as well as the starting and ending date of the rule. Additionally, the website highlights people that were only temporal replacements of a bishop. Unfortunately, there is no direct information on whether the rule ended in a pension, death, relocation, or discharge.

I take a list of dioceses from the official website of the Russian Orthodox Church (2025). For each diocese, I find the individual page on the website of the encyclopedia and manually write down the years of all transitions after 1990 as well as the names of the bishops. Unfortunately, I cannot automatize this process as all individual pages differ significantly in their structure. Hence, even though I double-check the data I collect, there is always room for human errors at this stage of the collection process.

For the dioceses located on the territory of the Russian Federation, there are three cases of a discharge of duties. The information about these cases can be found in legal documents of the Church Council (2020). The first case occurred in 2002, when the bishop of the Black Sea and Kuban was discharged after a car accident involving the death of a person. The other two cases occurred in 2020 in the diocese of Armavir-and-Labinsk (Krasnodar Krai) and the diocese of Kostomuksha-and-Kem (Republic of Karelia) accordingly. Both bishops were accused of alcohol abuse, and one of them was also charged with sexual misbehavior. I manually delete these three cases, as well as the according region-time-period observations from most of the analysis below.

I aggregate the data at the level of regions. For each region, I calculate the total number of transitions within the according dioceses, the number of dioceses where a transition happened, as well as a dummy on whether a transition happened in the main diocese. The difference between the first two variables is quite small, as it is possible but rare to have two transitions within one diocese within the six years between elections. I calculate the difference between the two to later address excess transitions as a measure of uncertainty. For all regions that are covered by a single diocese, I treat that single diocese as a main one. There are only two cases where multiple transitions happen within a main diocese.

I also manually find occasions where a transition happened due to a relocation. I treat a transition as a relocation if the name of the outgoing bishop coincides with the name of an incoming bishop in any other transition within a month post. This approach might, in fact, be erroneous, as in the tradition of the church, monks are sometimes given a new name when they enter a new duty. In most specifications below, I use the total number

of transitions or the dummy on main transitions as the main regressor. However, data on the number of transiting dioceses, or the number of transitions net of the relocation transitions, are used for robustness checks.

Additionally, I create a variable counting the number of new dioceses created within a region. This is not a steady process, as very few dioceses were created in the 2000s, while there was a large up-scaling of the Church in the period between 2011 and 2014 and a rather gradual expansion thereafter. I also count the total number of dioceses in the region. I will treat the former as one regressor in some specifications while I treat the latter as a control in most specifications.

Table 1 shows some descriptive statistics for my variables. The average number of transitions is 0.88 per region, while a transition in the archi-diocese happens in 37.7% of the region-time-period observations. There is an average number of 0.4 dioceses created in each region-time-period. The number of observations is 83 regions multiplied by 4, as I treat the Khanty-Mansiysk, Yamalo-Nenetsk, and Nenetsk autonomous regions separately, while I lose 3 observations in the voting data collection described below.

Table 1: Bishop Transitions

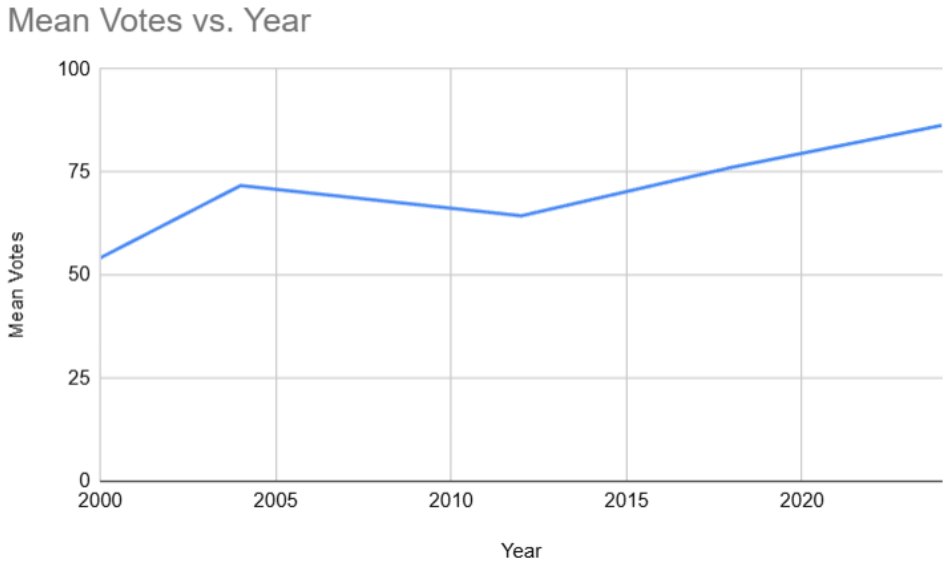
Variable	N	mean	sd
Number of Transitions	329	0.881	1.174
Transitions in Main	329	0.377	0.608
New Dioceses Created	329	0.395	0.813
Difference in Vote Share	326	8.11	11.44

3.2 Voting Outcomes

I collect data on votings from Central Election Commission of the Russian Federation (2024). For each region, I collect the share of votes cast for Vladimir Putin in the elections of 2000, 2004, 2012, 2018, and 2024. I calculate the difference for each term, including the difference between 2012 and 2004, when technically there was another term in between. Unfortunately, I did not understand whether and where I might find data on votings in specific municipalities or even polling stations, so I had to stick with regions and aggregate the data as described above. For some reason, I cannot find data on Kamchatka, Zabaikal, and Perm Krais prior to 2012.

Figure 1 shows the average share of votes for Vladimir Putin taken across regions. There is a clear upward trend, with the average change in the share of votes being 8.11 percentage points. Importantly, it should be noted that the Russian electoral system is accused of many flaws and falsifications, so there could be significant noise in the outcome measures that I have. However, these data are the best I have available, so I stick to them.

Figure 1: Average Share of Votes for Putin



Notes: The average is calculated across regions, not over the population.

4 Results

This Section shows the results of my project. Subsection 4.1 describes the Identification Strategy, while Subsection 4.2 checks on the validity of its assumptions. Subsection 4.3 shows the main results, while Subsection 4.4 provides robustness checks. Finally, Subsection 4.5 discusses the results and addresses heterogeneous treatment effects.

4.1 Empirical Strategy

For identification, I will use a staggered difference-in-differences analysis. This empirical strategy heavily relies on the assumption that regions and bishops for which a transition occurs do not differ from those regions where no transition happens. This allows to compare the average outcome where a transition occurred to an average outcome for observations where none happened. The specific regression is the following:

$$\triangle y_{rt} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 x_{rt} + \beta_2 c_{rt} + \alpha y_{r,t-1} + \gamma_r + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{rt}$$

where $\triangle y_{rt}$ is the first-difference in the share of votes between the current (t) and the previous $(t-1)$ election in region r, x_{rt} is a vector of regressors of interest, while c_{rt} is a vector of region-time specific controls and $y_{r,t-1}$ is the vote share in the previous election. Since I account for lagged vote shares, there is no difference for the coefficients of interest between taking the first-difference or the absolute share of votes as outcome. I choose the former one, as it is more suitable for interpretability.

The regressors of interest are calculated for the time period in between two elections, and are described in detail in Subsection 3.1. They include either the total number of

transitions, the number of dioceses with a transition within the region, a dummy for whether a transition happened in the main diocese, the number of new dioceses created within a region, or some combination of the above. The controls include the total number of dioceses at the beginning of the time period, that is, calculated at the day after the previous election. I also wanted to add the age of the bishop as a control, but due to time limitations, I was not able to collect that data. To account for trends or mean regressions, I include the previous vote share as a control. As a diocese might be less likely to be treated a second time in a row if it was treated before, in some specifications I also include the previous treatment value as a control.

Technically, since I expect some effect on voting outcomes, I also assume that the new bishop does not differ from the old one in any characteristic except the *mandate* he receives from the Patriarch and, perhaps, his age. This means I might be able to compare leaders that were placed prior to President Putin or Patriarch Kirill and did not receive any political tasks in their mandate when entering duty to those leaders that were placed during the time of United Russia power and that apparently did receive some specific politically oriented tasks.

It is quite reasonable to assume that the death or reaching of pension age of a bishop is independent of the diocese he oversees. That would make the transition shock quite exogenous relative to specific diocese-time characteristics. This would mean that on average a diocese with a transition were the same as a diocese without a transition, which would allow to straightforwardly calculate the average treatment effect (ATE) simply by comparing treated and untreated dioceses.

However, for variables aggregated at the region level this assumption would somewhat fail, as, clearly, even after controlling for fixed effects, a region with five dioceses differs from a region with two dioceses both in unobserved region-time characteristics and in the expected number of transitions within the region. Hence, I obviously need to control for the total number of dioceses.

There are other concerns about the identification assumption, as, for example, younger new bishops might be placed for duty into smaller dioceses. They later either end up being transferred to more demanding duties at some point in time, or they might end up serving a longer time within one diocese, making it technically somewhat different from the average. Moreover, there is a clear difference between transiting and non-transiting dioceses in terms of bishop age, as the one who dies or reaches pension age appears to be older than the average, while the one who enters duty appears to be younger than the average. Moreover, as the Russian Orthodox Church expanded over the recent time, the new bishop might simply differ in training, meaning he might have received more theological education than the old bishop or the average one. It would be very helpful to control for average bishop age, or the age of the main bishop of the region, to address these concerns at least to some extent, but, unfortunately, I am not able to do that as I

did not have the time to collect the data.

4.2 Pre-Trend Analysis

In order to test my assumptions, I consider previous trends of the voting behavior in treated and untreated regions. If dioceses with transitions are indeed similar to dioceses without transitions, we should observe similar paths prior to treatment. Notably, this is a necessity test, and if we do indeed observe parallel trends, it does not mean I have proof of my assumption, but it only means that I do not have a contradiction.

There are two complications in a pre-trend analysis for my data. First, as I have a staggered difference-in-difference regression, treatments can appear and disappear multiple times throughout the observation history. Moreover, for some regressors, the treatment value is non-binary, which makes it harder to compare pre-trends. Technically, it would be best to show graphs for all different groups of treatment values, but this is nearly impossible, as there can be up to 5 groups of treatment and I have a total of 83 regional observations.

I decide to check pre-trends for the occurrence of a transition in the main diocese, as this variable takes on two values, and as for most region-time observations there is no more than one main transition. Moreover, transitions in main dioceses are the same for all regions, while regular transitions and diocese creations might differ relative to the size of the mitropoly.

Appendix Figures A3 and A4 show the results of the analysis. Visually, it appears that the parallel pre-trend assumption holds quite well, with the exception of treatment in the period between 2012 and 2018. Notably, graphically, the pre-trends appear to behave better when controlling for previous treatment. Intuitively, a region that has a transition today is less likely to have a transition yesterday, so it might start differing from its neighbor before treatment, simply because the untreated neighbor is more likely to be treated at the previous stage.

For a more formal test of the parallel pre-trend assumption, in regressions not reported here, I include lead values of the treatments. No coefficient on lead values is significantly distinct from zero, which suggest a valid assumption. At the same time, as we will see further, neither do I get significant coefficients in the main regressions, so any explanation for the zero-results below can be similarly applied here.

4.3 Main Results

Table 2 shows the main results of my project. We can see that the number of leadership changes appears not to affect the difference in vote shares for Vladimir Putin with an insignificant estimate of -0.13 percentage points. Not even transitions in main archidioceses show to have any effects. If anything, the coefficients seem to be rather negative, not estimated precisely, and economically fairly close to zero at an estimate of -0.63

percentage points. Both zero results hold when restricting the sample to mostly-Orthodox regions and excluding the two megapoli of Moscow and Saint-Petersburg.

Table 2: Bishop Transitions and Change in Vote Share

	Difference in Vote Share for Vladimir Putin					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Number of Transitions	−0.132	−0.191				
	(0.330)	(0.285)				
Transition in Main			−0.630	−0.395		
			(0.558)	(0.520)		
New Dioceses Created					0.990**	1.421***
					(0.425)	(0.489)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Region FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	326	286	326	286	326	286
Mean of Dep. Variable	8.11	8.33	8.11	8.33	8.11	8.33
Adj. R-squared	0.800	0.839	0.801	0.839	0.803	0.846

Notes: Columns (1), (3), and (5) report results on the whole sample. Columns (2), (4), and (6) exclude all majority-muslim regions as well as Moscow, Moscow Region, and St.Petersburg. The outcome variables and regressors are described above. Controls include the lagged vote share for Vladimir Putin and a constant. Robust standard errors are clustered at the region level and are reported in parentheses. The p-values are reported as * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

At the same time, coefficients on the creation of a new diocese are significantly different from zero, with a correlational point estimate of about a 1 percentage point increase in vote shares for each diocese created in a region. I could technically interpret this as some effect of an increase in religious power, some effect of voters rewarding politicians for providing access to more religious services. But let us face it, most probably, this is a result of an omitted variable bias or even perhaps some reverse causality. Note that there is no nice and clean exogenous variation in diocese creation, as nobody dies, nobody reaches pension age, but simply someone makes the decision to create a diocese. Hence, it seems highly likely that in some regions there might simply be an increase in patriotism, leading to more votes for the ruling party, as well as a larger amount of traditional believers, leading to an increased provision of religious services.

Notably, the positive effects of diocese creation could also simply be the results of a spurious regression. There was a large expansion in administrative and spiritual leadership staff in the Orthodox Church between 2011 and 2014. At the same time, there was a large increase in the reported number of votes for Putin between the elections of 2012 and 2018. Perhaps, the significant coefficients simply capture a coincidence in timing.

4.4 Robustness Checks

In this Subsection, I provide several robustness checks of my results from above. Table 3 shows the coefficients for alternative measures of transitions, while Table 4 shows the regressions from above, controlling for the total number of dioceses within a region at the beginning of the electoral cycle. The estimated coefficients appear to be very close to the previous results. The number of dioceses with a transition has a coefficient of -0.25 percentage points. Excess transitions, representing uncertainty in leadership, also appear to be irrelevant. The results also hold when combining the two distinct regressors of transitions and diocese creation, suggesting some orthogonality between the two. Finally, controlling for the total number of dioceses at the beginning of the electoral cycle also does not change the estimates and even appears to make them more negative.

Table 3: Bishop Transitions and Change in Vote Share. Part 2

	Difference in Vote Share for Vladimir Putin					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Clean transitions	−0.245	−0.393	−0.020	−0.133		
	(0.462)	(0.428)	(0.486)	(0.438)		
Excess Transitions	0.118	0.253	−0.118	−0.026		
	(0.874)	(0.841)	(0.887)	(0.863)		
New Dioceses Created			0.989**	1.403***		
			(0.438)	(0.490)		
Created Diocese					2.372**	3.106***
					(0.916)	(0.873)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Region FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	326	286	326	286	326	286
Mean of Dep. Variable	8.114	8.332	8.114	8.332	8.114	8.332
Adj. R-squared	0.799	0.838	0.802	0.844	0.805	0.849

Notes: Columns (1), (3), and (5) report results on the whole sample. Columns (2), (4), and (6) exclude all majority-muslim regions as well as Moscow, Moscow Region, and St.Petersburg. The outcome variable is described above. The first regressor is the number of transitioning dioceses within a region. The second regressor is the amount of double-transitions within one diocese of a region. The third regressor shows the number of dioceses created. The last regressor is a dummy for whether any new diocese was created. Controls include the lagged vote share for Vladimir Putin and a constant. Robust standard errors are clustered at the region level and reported in parentheses. The p-values are reported as * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

In regressions not reported here, I also do robustness checks for transitions caused by relocations, a check for the inclusion of the three cases of duty discharges into the sample, and separately consider transitions happening after 2009 or those where a pre-Putin bishop gets replaced with a post-Putin one. None of these regressions change the results. Especially those where I delete like half of the sample.

Table 4: Bishop Transitions and Change in Vote Share. Part 3

	Difference in Vote Share for Vladimir Putin					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Number of Transitions	−0.578	−0.387				
	(0.348)	(0.327)				
Transition in Main			−0.859	−0.491		
			(0.548)	(0.518)		
New Dioceses Created					1.603***	1.893***
					(0.513)	(0.505)
Number of Dioceses	1.550**	0.739	1.351**	0.587	1.980***	1.395**
	(0.703)	(0.678)	(0.624)	(0.585)	(0.700)	(0.567)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Region FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	326	286	326	286	326	286
Mean of Dep. Variable	8.114	8.332	8.114	8.332	8.114	8.332
Adj. R-squared	0.803	0.839	0.804	0.839	0.811	0.849

Notes: Columns (1), (3), and (5) report results on the whole sample. Columns (2), (4), and (6) exclude all majority-muslim regions as well as Moscow, Moscow Region, and St.Petersburg. The outcome variables and regressors are described above. The number of dioceses in a region is taken as of the beginning of each electoral term. Controls include the lagged vote share for Vladimir Putin and a constant. Robust standard errors are clustered at the region level and are reported in parentheses. The p-values are reported as * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

4.5 Discussion

There are several distinct reasons for why I could get the zero-results. First, there could indeed not be any effect of bishop transitions on political outcomes. Second, I might fail to find precisely estimated effects due to noisy measurement errors. Finally, an average zero effect might in fact represent a sum of significant positive and negative effects.

Precisely estimated effects might be quite likely in the following two cases. First, I might be wrong about assuming that the mandates of religious leaders change over time. My anecdotal case from Appendix A2 suggests that there might be some recommendations towards bishops regarding relations with the government, but these might indeed be limited to recommendations and not be followed precisely. Moreover, and even more likely, the mandates of existing leaders might also change over time, as they still might feel some social pressure to support the ruling party to the same extent a new bishop does. Second, perhaps the mandates indeed do change, and perhaps bishops do even indeed increase their effort regarding political goals relative to spiritual ones, but perhaps these efforts simply are fruitless. In particular, it might be quite likely that true believers filter the information they receive from their popes in order to only take up the spiritual part but ignore the political one.

Next, there is some significant evidence that voting results in Russia might be falsified and misreported (Enikolopov et al., 2013). This means that there are significant measurement errors that might in the good case bias the result toward zero and in the worst case be correlated with bishop effort to affect political outcomes.

Finally, my difference-in-differences approach aggregates all region-time observations into one homogeneous average treatment effect. At the same time, treatment effects might differ significantly for different regions and different transitioning bishops. Hence, by averaging, I might simply not be able to identify distinct effects in distinct settings.

There might be some heterogeneity in the difference between the exiting and incoming bishop. Notably, in the original work of Jones and Olken (2005) the authors estimate the effects on outcome *variance*, not the outcomes themselves. If a politically-oriented leader is replaced by an apolitical one, the effects might be opposite from the reverse transition. This would result in a zero treatment estimate, but would also show an increase in variance. I do not follow the original work, as my goal was to identify the direct effects.

Notably, there is some prospect for future work here, as I could actually estimate the direction of transition. Each diocese has an official website, and most of them have an individual page on Russia's social network VK. It might be possible to collect data on the number of political and apolitical posts before and after the transition. A preliminary examination of some websites showed that there are indeed significant amounts of both sorts of posts, so I might have sufficient variation here. This might allow me to estimate some specific heterogeneous effects if I wish to return to this project someday.

Moreover, I am not able to distinguish between death and pension related transitions. There might indeed be some heterogeneity in this place, as sending bishops to pension is also a choice (even though it can only be made at a very specific period in time). It should actually be quite possible to distinguish these cases once I collect data on bishop age. However, once again, I was not able to accomplish that task yet as it would require me to search the biographies of every single religious leader throughout 25 years.

Finally, the effects definitely differ for regions with a high and low amount of orthodox believers. Clearly, the larger the share of people that visit religious services, the larger the share of people that a bishop might potentially affect. I address this concern to some extent when excluding majority-Muslim regions from the sample.

Unfortunately, I could not find a single reliable datasource that would allow me to estimate the share of Orthodox people. Not even VCIOM or Levada do publish any similar datasets on a regular basis. Moreover, people who claim to be Orthodox also vary significantly. Some visit church every week, some do it once a year, and some do not even actually believe in God, but just randomly decide to belong to a specific group or claim to be believers due to social desirability. And while I can somewhat trust dummy categories like Muslim/Non-Muslim on the internet, I would rather very much restrain myself from

taking measures of the share of Orthodox from some random websites.

Technically, data on three measures of Orthodox beliefs can be found in the Russia Longitudinal Monitoring survey. However, the three measures only partly correlate, somewhat contradict themselves, and, most importantly, cover only 33 regions. And I mean, who am I to restrict my sample even further when I already have estimates very close to zero. Hence, I highly doubt that an extension of my study in this direction to check for heterogeneity will be possible in the next several years.

5 Conclusion

In my project, I empirically examine the political influence of religious leaders in contemporary Russia. By analyzing whether natural transitions of bishops in the Russian Orthodox Church affect regional vote shares for the long-standing incumbent, Vladimir Putin, I aim to test for the presence of an entrenched, strategic relationship between religious and political power.

The main finding of my analysis is a consistent lack of statistically significant effects. The timing of a bishop's death or retirement does not appear to be a meaningful driver of changes in electoral support for the ruling party at the regional level. This result is robust to several alternative specifications, including changes in the regressors of interest and sample restrictions.

While I identify a correlational relationship between the creation of new dioceses and higher vote shares, this relationship is more plausibly explained by reverse causality or omitted variable bias – such as increases in patriotism – rather than a causal effect of a strategic religious administrative expansion.

The absence of a sizable effect can be interpreted in several ways. First, it may indicate that the Russian Orthodox Church and its leaders genuinely refrain from, or are ineffective in, exerting direct electoral influence, despite some anecdotal evidence I provide regarding political mandates. Second, an effect might be masked by significant measurement error in Russian electoral data. Finally, it could represent the averaging of opposing heterogeneous effects, meaning that bishops actually do matter but are not strategically placed.

There are several potential options for future research, as I might want to analyze the content of social media and other sources of public communication within a diocese in order to measure political engagement directly. I might also want to instead investigate effects on the variance, rather than the mean, of electoral outcomes, similar to what Jones and Olken (2005) do. For now, however, the empirical evidence suggests that the mechanism of political influence through the natural turnover of regional religious leaders is either non-existent or too subtle to be identified with my data and methods.

Note on AI Usage

As always, I use various AI for literature suggestions. I use Overleaf-inbuilt GPT for grammar and text revision, as well as structure and cleaning suggestions. I also ask ChatGPT for help with writing the Abstract, as well as suggesting a structure for the Conclusion of the project, since I find these are tasks where a clear structure is more important than the application of human creativity. Obviously, I revise and adjust any text or structure suggestions before implementing them into my work.

Note on Self-Plagiarism

I should explicitly point out that my current project for the Development Economics course also touches on Religion in Russia. That work examines the effects of building churches and expanding religious services on several developmental outcomes such as fertility, education, and crime. The data sources, data collection, data analysis, and general writing work differ entirely for the two courses. However, there definitely are some intersections in the literature work as well as a common institutional setting I study. This means that I might have had to read fewer papers than my average classmate, and one might want to account for that when grading. If needed, I am ready to share my other project with the TA for a more detailed inspection of the issue.

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Figure A1: Vologda Mitropoly



Source: This picture is stolen from the internet and I unfortunately cannot give a specific reference as the website it comes from appears to be deleted. This is, however, the best graphical representation of a mitropoly that I was able to find, so I am very sorry for the inconvenience here.

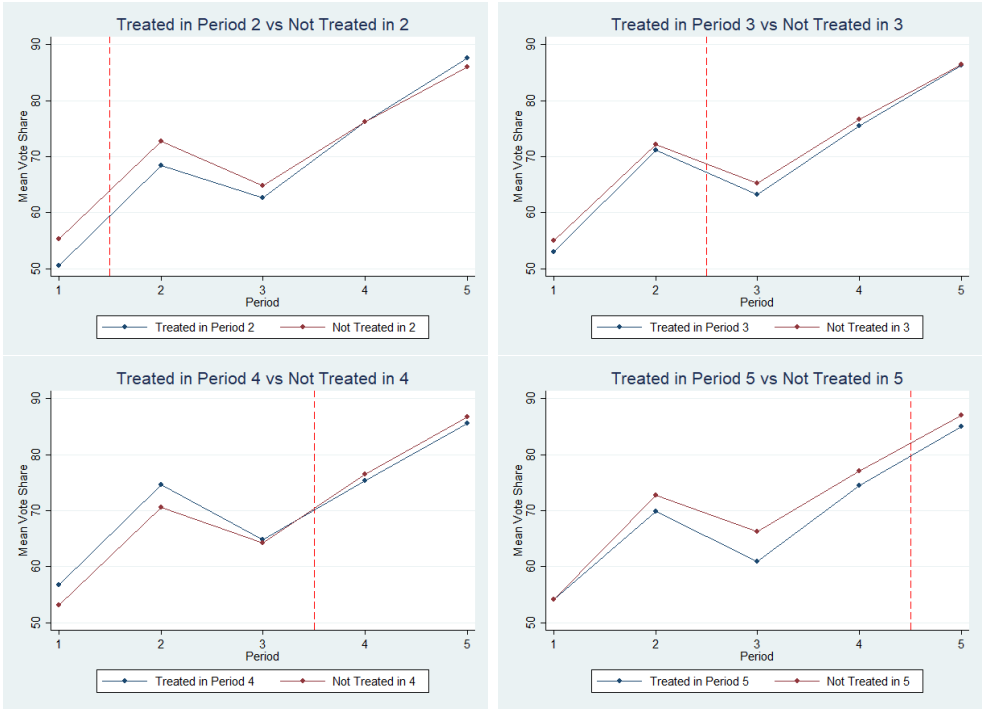
Figure A2: Inauguration Speech for the Naming of the Kasim-and-Sasov Bishop

Враг рода человеческого ополчается на Церковь, старается отвратить от нее людей, привнести разделения, распространить заблуждения и ложные идеи. Так было во все времена — так происходит и сейчас. Поэтому, стоя *с оружием правды в правой и левой руке* (2 Кор. 6:7) и *испытывая, что благоугодно Богу* (Еф. 5:10), стремись сугубое архипастырское попечение проявлять не только о созидании православных храмов, хотя, конечно, это очень и очень важная сегодня задача, которая должна стоять перед епископом, но иоб устроении монашеских общин во вверенном тебе церковном уделе, а также о духовно-нравственном воспитании подрастающего поколения, об окормлении военнослужащих, о развитии просветительской деятельности и, что особенно важно, о пополнении клира епархии новыми достойными тружениками алтаря Господня, дабы *слово Божие росло и распространялось* (Деян. 12:24).

Пребывая *в единстве духа и союзе мира* (Еф. 4:3) с Высокопреосвященнейшим Марком, митрополитом Рязанским и Михайловским, главой Рязанской митрополии, ныне участвовавшим в твоей епископской хиротонии, выстраивай добрые и конструктивные взаимоотношения с государственными властями на местах.

Source: https://www.patriarchia.ru/article/117104.

Figure A3: Pre-Trends for Different Treatment Times



Notes: This figure shows pre-trends for treated and untreated regions at different periods in time. The upper-left compares regions treated in 2000-2004 to untreated in that period. The upper-right represents treatment between 2004 and 2012. The lower-left, treatment between 2012 and 2018. The lower-right, treatment between 2018 and 2024.

Figure A4: Pre-Trends for Pre-Treated and Untreated Groups



Notes: This figure shows pre-trends for treated and untreated regions between 2018 and 2024. The upper-left takes regions treated in 2012-2018, while the upper-right represents those untreated in that period. The lower-left shows regions treated between 2004 and 2018, while the lower-right those that were not.